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Sudan, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Central African Republic

Section Title(S)

9 SANZA , A CHARACTERISTIC FEATURE OF ZANDE LANGUAGE AND THOUGHT 1956

(21) In old days also a man's blood-brother would try to warn him as he entered court that there was trouble brewing for him there and that he had better get away quickly. He did this by greeting his blood-brother in the joking manner of greeting that obtains between blood-brothers, that is, by shaking his hand, and in doing so pressing a finger into the centre of the hand or scraping it with a finger. Since in the past Azande did not shake hands in greeting unless they were blood-brothers a man who did this would be suspect if his blood-brother escaped punishment or vengeance (*bape*). One way of escaping was to throw one's spear a little way as though in play and then again till one was out of sight. If a man did this after his blood-brother had shaken hands with him the blood-brother would be involved in complicity, so men adopted a new way of giving warning, the *sanza bangirise*, the *sanza* of the eyes. The man giving the warning quickly closed both eyes, screwed up his face, and turned his head round from the person whom he wished to warn, to urge him to get away at once.

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(22) A man's barkcloth is out of place and his genitals are exposed. Another wants to make malicious fun of him, so he catches the eye of a friend and by moving his own head round he directs it to the exposure.

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I have given a few examples to illustrate what Azande mean by *sanza* and how they think of it. As we have noted, a *sanza* is a circumlocutory form of speech or action in which words and gestures have hidden meanings different from their manifest meanings and generally malicious. All Azande employ *sanza* to some extent, though some more than others; and some are able to see a man's intentions beneath the cloak of words he throws over them more easily than others. People who habitually speak in *sanza* aim to be spiteful

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without exposing themselves to retaliation. They say 222 something nasty about someone in the presence of others without his seeing the point of what is said while the others see it and go home and joke about it. A man says about his wife, whom he dislikes, in the presence of other women 'this stupid dog, I keep it only because of my cough'. A dog licks the phlegm its master spits out. The inner meaning of the words is 'this stupid woman [his wife], I keep her only because she hoes my gardens'. Were the wife to understand this she would make a row, but should she do so then or later, someone in the meanwhile having explained it to her, her husband would feign innocence, saying that he was speaking only of his dog and meant no more than he said. He is careful, when making the remark, to look towards his dog.

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